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Forget Linux

The future of our digital freedom is clouded.

How muft and mukt will you find yourself in the next 10 years? Here's my bold prediction: almost all the software you use may become muft and mukt, but you will find your digital freedom almost vaporised in this new decade. You will become a digital slave with muft and mukt software.

Everything else

I attribute your imminent digital slavery to the overwhelming success of the Free Software Foundation (FSF) and to the FOSS movement at large. Their mandate has been to fight for the freedom and openness of software. Alas, software are not people and hence the irony. Some may debate that the adoption of Open Standards in computing is therefore even more important than just the adoption and development of FOSS. Standards aren't people, either. The ground-breaking initiative at CreativeCommons.org brings freedom to knowledge, education, entertainment, and all other forms of authored works. Not necessarily to people. Nevertheless, this decade will see an exponential surge in the use of CreativeCommons.org licences. Bringing digital freedom to people is another dimension altogether, and one that's not yet been touched.

The nurturer vs defender

Some of you may point at the Electronic Frontier Foundation, affectionately known as EFF. According to its website, "EFF is the leading civil liberties group defending your rights in the digital world." Do consider spending at least 15 minutes browsing through the Web pages to see how this outfit fights Bluetooth and nail, taking on governments, multinational corporations and cartels, who trample on your rights. Most of EFF's work and expertise is focused around the United States, though the EFF does strike at beach-heads in several other countries from time to time.

Indians are in dire need of a formidable and indigenous EFF. If you're one of those helpless Indians frustrated in the face of spam marketing calls and text messages, or have been victimised by inflated electricity bills due to a 'computer error', you'll know why. In fact, it's about time some strong and committed individuals got together to launch EFF or something similar in India, within this year.

By its own admission, EFF is a 'defender' of your digital freedom. Which means that it may choose to take up your case legally; file public interest litigations; and run advocacy programs. What I dream about is not an

organisation and a movement that fights for your digital freedom, but nurtures it. Am not looking for the doctor in the emergency ward, but the yoga, fitness, ayurveda and meditation guru, all rolled into one—to help me live a healthy, fulfilled, peaceful and blissful life.

Man is a software animal

This think tank needs to address questions and find solutions to problems in this next wave of computing. In the previous wave, man was merely a software animal. In this wave, man is a social animal, with software to boot. So, if my data is stuck in the Internet cloud, the value is not in my tweets, blogs, and comments alone, but the sharing, re-tweeting, commenting, and collaboration that happens around it. I could get the entire Facebook engine as copyleft software, run it on my own FOSS-based servers, but how do I get the social wealth embedded within Facebook; a wealth of which I too am a part; to which I've also contributed? Who owns this? Facebook, or all of us? Do I own my recommendations and reviews on Amazon.com? If so, do I get a share of the revenue they help generate for Amazon.com? These questions are one

of many to be raised with Google services, Twitter, Flickr, Last.fm, and everywhere else you dwell on the Web as a social animal. I haven't even raised questions focused around mobile phone software

and services, where all consumers are being taken on a solid telecommute-ride by service-providers and their cronies.

All these questions are deeply thought provoking. These next 10 years are going to be the most exciting, challenging and stimulating times in the history of computing yet. Am buzzing and bursting with ideas, and look forward to sharing your ideas and suggestions as we explore uncharted territory, month after month, in this new avatar of Freedom Yug. Here Be Dragons and Rakshasas. Bring me my bow of burning gold. Bring me my arrows of desire. Bring me my spear: O Web clouds unfurl. Bring me my chariots of fire. 

**"Man is a social animal,
with software to boot."**

About Niyam

Inspired by the vision of Osho. Copyright February 2010: Niyam Bhushan. freedomyugs@gmail.com. First published in *LINUX For You* magazine. Verbatim copying, publishing and distribution of this article is encouraged in any language and medium, so long as this copyright notice is preserved. In Hindi, 'muft' means 'free-of-cost', and 'mukt' means 'with freedom'.